



New wave of wider EV adoption?

Satvik Pandey satvik@digit.in

All ardent motorsport fans in India rejoiced when it was announced that the country would be hosting a Formula E race in Hyderabad as early as next year. The FIA, which is the governing body of Formula E races, has confirmed that Hyderabad will be hosting a Formula E E-Prix on February 11, 2023. This could potentially open up a new door for wider adoption of electric vehicles in India. In this article, we will explore the possibilities of the same and look into how and why Formula E could be the push that India needs to shift to an EV-dominant automobile market.

WASN'T IT FORMULA 1?

Over the last few years, there has been a monumental shift in the outlook of motorsport governing bodies across the globe to ensure that their sport's functioning is environmentally friendlier than it was. Formula 1, for example, has already started making changes. After the introduction of turbo-hybrid engines in its cars, shifting away from the V8 engines, the next goal for the sport is to get to net-zero emissions by the year 2030. The last time Formula 1 raced in India; the cars were running on the older V8 engines, which

consumed much more fuel and had equally high emissions.

Formula E was launched with the vision of serving as a benchmark motorsport event, where cutting-edge automobile performance was put on display without causing much harm to the environment. And it has been successful in doing so too. The controlled use of tyres, deployment of street circuits for races, and the promotion of environmentally sustainable entertainment has garnered a lot of attention and praise. While there is a scope for improvement, overall, the impact has been commendable.

The sport has also seen several drivers jump the boat from Formula

1 to Formula E over the years. There are others like Nico Rosberg. The 2016 FIA Formula 1 World Champion, who, despite having never raced in the series, has been a supporter and owns a stake in a couple of EV racing teams too!

WHAT IMPACT?

Over the years, Formula E has been the battleground for EV manufacturers all over the world to showcase the cutting-edge technological developments with their car and engine designs. Indian car manufacturer Mahindra also has a team racing in the series under an Indian license in Formula E. The ecosystem here is like an inverted pyramid. There are a host of cutting-edge developments put to display in Formula E cars.

Over time, these trickle down to the mass market EVs. At that stage, the fact that the feature was first showcased in a race car by the same car maker becomes a huge selling point.

Just like it is the case with MotoGP and other races that make owing a toned down variant of that vehicle 'cool', Formula E has made EVs 'cool' since its inaugural season. If a bike manufacturer wins a MotoGP rider's or constructor's title, their lineup of motorcycles globally gets a boost; in the same way, if a Formula E team wins a driver's or a constructor's title, then their sales are very likely to go up. Each win with a newer generation car provides further push to their agenda.

